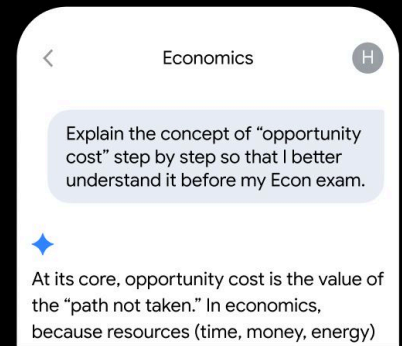


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NEWS

The ultimate guide to tenting at Duke: What it is, how it works and why it's worth it

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Tenting & Basketball Tips



THIS STORY IS PART OF A SERIES:

How To Duke



By How to Duke Staff

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What is tenting?

Tenting is the process that students attempt in order to get free tickets to the home Duke vs. UNCmen's basketball game. Each year, students pitch tents on the grassy patch

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Tents each have 12 undergrads, and "Tenting Seasons" can range from January to either February or, for longer tenting seasons, the Saturday before spring break starts. A "long" season is determined by whether the Duke vs. UNC game is played at home first (February) or away first (March). When the home game is in February, the competition to get a tent is traditionally more competitive, since students wouldn't have to sleep outside as much.

What is a Line Monitor?



Student Line Monitors are in contact with Duke Athletics to run tenting. They are ironically hated because they wake students up in the middle of the night! Students can apply to be a line monitor at the end of every season, which is desirable because line monitors automatically get into the UNC game without tenting.

How I found my tent.

When I started going to basketball games as a freshman for the 2021-22 season, I randomly stumbled upon one of the most die-hard Cameron Crazies through a mutual club. What you'll find is that everyone wants to go to the intramural team scrimmage (Countdown to Craziness), but shortly after that, all of the "Cameron Casuals" disappear. I struggled to find someone to go to the games with. So, I ended up DMing that die-hard fan on GroupMe, and he said that I could come to the next game with him.



wildest dreams come true: The seniors ask if I would like to join the tent. Of course, I said yes, but I was confused about what tenting really meant.



Black vs. Blue vs. White/Flex tenting

There are four tiers of tenting: Black, Blue, White and Flex. Each has different time commitments and rules, but all tents have 12 members.

- **Black tents** stay out the longest and get the best seats. You'll need 10 people overnight (1–7 a.m. weekdays, 2:30–7 a.m. weekends) and six during the day. If more than 80 Black/Blue tents register, you'll take a test on Duke trivia and basketball.
- **Blue tents** have lighter requirements (six overnight, three during the day) and get decent spots behind Black tents.
- **White tents** skip the test and heavy overnight shifts, but face the Race to the Secret Spots — a late-night campus-wide clue hunt.
- **Flex tents** are White tents that didn't make the cutoff in the Race but still could get in, depending on space. They're at the very back of the line.

The difficulty of getting a tent depends on student interest, which is usually based on how good the team is that year. Let's just say, it was no surprise to anyone that this past year's

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What is the Black tenting test?

The test determines which 80 tents get into K-Ville, and while it's *supposed* to be about the current team, it's become more pop culture than basketball. Yes, you'll need to know stats, positions and player hometowns, but also weird trivia like what snack someone promoted in an NIL deal.

It's sparked debate: Should someone who's barely been to games but aces the trivia get in over a die-hard fan? Honestly, I'm not sure why it's not more basketball-focused. But hey, if at least one person in your tent is a Duke MBB encyclopedia, you've got a shot whether you're a bball fanatic or not.

Setting up your tent

Once you've secured a Black tent, your group usually pitches it that weekend, splitting the cost of a large tent and gathering essentials like pallets, cardboard, tarps and lanterns. Shoe bins, flashlights and battery-powered lights are also common tenting items.

On Saturday morning, tenters gather early (some even camp out) to claim plots spray-painted by Duke Athletics. When line monitors give the go-ahead, everyone rushes in and sets up. Die-hard fans aim for spots closest to Cameron (better for media exposure *and* for staying warm during tent checks).

Everyone brings sleeping bags and blankets. Some tents go even further by rotating cots or foam mattresses for a better night's sleep.

What tenting is actually like

Each season, line monitors release a document with all the tenting rules — from how tent checks work to what weather qualifies for “grace,” when you're allowed to sleep inside. When I first tented, grace only applied below 25 degrees, but it's now 32 degrees, which makes a big difference. You also get a grace hour after every tent check to eat, change or just warm up.

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just powered through by repeating: "I just want Lively to get eight blocks and then it will be worth it."

Man, oh man, tent checks are the worst. Line monitors run through K-Ville with megaphones and alarms, and you have to show your DukeCard to confirm your tent has enough people. Miss once? You get a warning. Miss again? You're out, stuck behind the Flex tents.

To avoid chaos, most tents run on shared spreadsheets with assigned shifts. Everyone's expected to pull equal hours, and many tents reuse tracker templates passed down from previous years (some even auto-calculate hours for you).

Managing classes and homework

Tenting doesn't pause academics — your classes and assignments keep coming. Thankfully, Duke Athletics provides a heated study tent with tables and chargers (personal tent heaters aren't allowed).

I planned to take harder classes in the fall, since staying focused while tenting is tough. Some people even study for the MCAT while tenting — it's doable if you take advantage of downtime and quieter day shifts.

My tent came up with hacks to stay productive, like taking turns playing white noise in AirPods so others could concentrate without missing tent checks. Some tents bring fold-up chairs and mini tables for easier studying.

If you want to tent all four years *and* study abroad, consider going abroad in the fall instead of spring — that way you'll be back in time for K-Ville.

What was my tent dynamic like?

For my first time tenting, I was friends with everyone and would often come to the tent, even when I wasn't on shift, just because it was fun. My second time tenting, I randomly

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But I've heard stories of friend groups getting splintered during tenting because of the stress of some people being late to their shifts or not putting in enough hours. However, openly communicating about problems and scheduling your hours before the tent is pitched can significantly decrease the chance of this happening to you.

How to find a tent

The Line Monitors offer people the chance to post how many empty spots they have in their tent on a spreadsheet for people looking for a tent, since it can be hard to find a group of 12. Most tents I have seen are formed of a hodgepodge of friend groups instead of having a solid friend group of 12. There were three friend groups plus me in my second tent, but it all worked out!

What are P-Checks?

Before tenting ends, there's an event called "P-Checks" where all 12 members from each tent have to be in K-Ville for tent checks throughout the night. It is a massive party to mark the end of tenting, with Duke Athletics providing food trucks and plenty of water for those who might be celebrating a bit too hard. Students who didn't tent are invited to come as well! However, students can email the line monitors if they have extenuating circumstances that would lead them to miss P-Checks, such as sickness, and they can do a makeup P-Checks at another time.

Final tenting test and seating order

At the end of tenting, all Black tents take a final test on Duke MBB history to determine lineup order. My freshman year, our study guide was over 100 pages long — but taking the test on Coach K Court with Coach Scheyer and players stopping by to thank us made it all worth it.

There are also optional spirit events (like tennis or wrestling matches) where Black tenters can earn extra points to boost their tent's ranking. Tent 1 is the best spot.

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Various quads and clubs host big watch parties, and the campus sports bar, Krafthouse, sets up chairs outside their restaurant for students to come for that big fan environment. Plus, the game day itself is fun because the campus is buzzing with events outside of K-Ville, such as a cappella showcases and games on the quads.

However, all of this centers around a massive bench in the middle of the main Abele Quad where, if we win, everyone runs over to watch the bench burn! It is a prearranged event with the Durham fire department and police there for safety concerns, but it is the perfect place for photo ops for tenters and non-tenter alike!

Hacks I wish I knew before tenting

- Before the study tent goes up, the only outlet in K-Ville is on the Card Gym wall near the line-up spot. Yes, you might look suspicious crawling out of the bushes, but it works!
- Also, there's a massive cardboard box crusher outside Krafthouse. I once asked someone breaking down boxes if we could take some to pad our tent, and they said yes! I'm not sure if this is still allowed, but it's worth the ask.

Tenting definitely isn't for everyone, but if you're even a little into the Duke basketball Crazie culture, it's one of the most immersive parts of student life. Best of luck, future tenters!

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Written by Duke students, for Duke students.

The How to Duke Staff is a team of student and alum contributors at The Chronicle focused on providing practical, first-hand insight into life at Duke.

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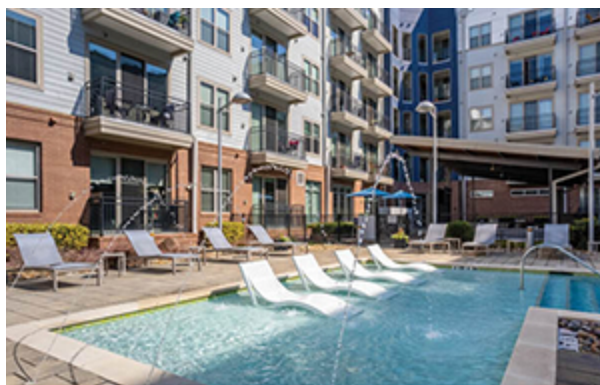
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